

phones operate for around 22 hours on a single charge. Approximate price is \$200 (Rs 9,500).

Etymotic ER4-S

Sealed earphones. Trust us, there's absolutely nothing better than sealed phones such as these for your daily commute. Plug them inside your ears and you can hear nothing from the outside—*nothing!* The drivers are tiny, and if you open up the phones, you'll find something about a millimetre in diameter pumping sound into your ears—this is a marvel of technology. But alas, as



you might expect, the bass is less than perfect—but you can't expect booming, thumping bass emanating from a one-millimetre orifice: that would simply be too demanding on technology! Treble and mids, however, are near-perfect, and even if you aren't in a noisy environment, the noise isolation makes for a surreal listening experience.

A further note about the bass is in order here: bass isn't just about thumping and booming. For all your lives thus far, you've probably associated bass with just that—thumping and booming. But with sealed earphones, the bass sounds different. It's very hard to describe it: one way of saying it would be that you don't "feel" the bass, you actually "hear" it. So is this more accurate reproduction? We can't say. Bass is a contentious issue, so you'll just have to listen to these phones to decide for yourself.

But how do you sample these phones without buying them? Our advice would be to take our word for it—forget about the bass